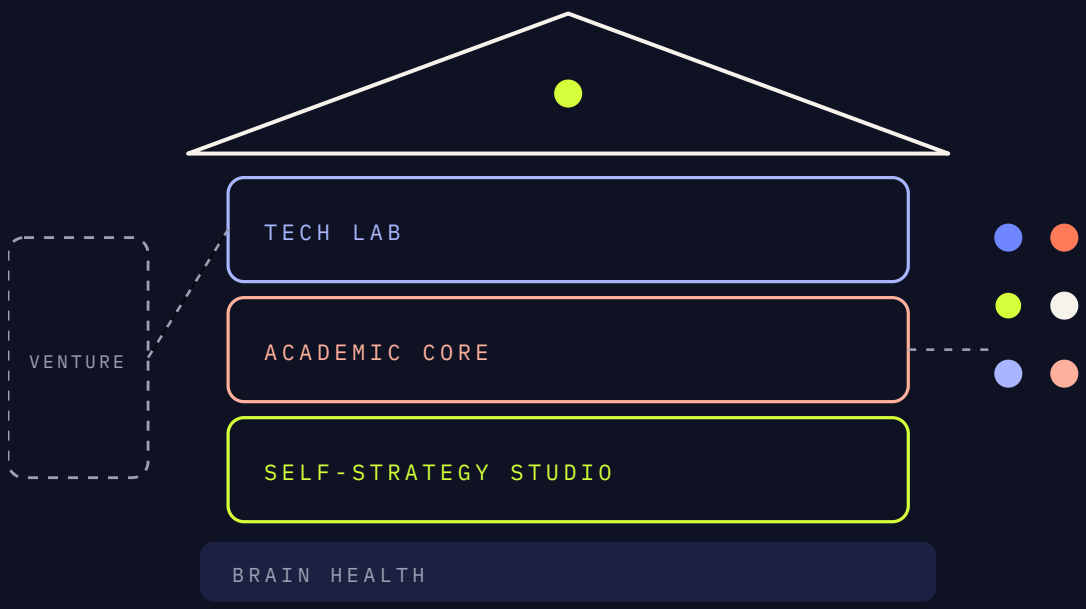
INSIGHT REPORT NO. 2 · 2026

THE SELF-LEARNING STACK™ SERIES

Building Brain Capital

A blueprint for the tech university and the corporate academy of the future



Anna Ambrozevich

ARCHITECT OF HUMAN SYSTEMS

RECTORS · ACADEMY LEADERS · L&D



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Anna Ambrozevich

ARCHITECT OF HUMAN SYSTEMS

I work on one question: how do people, and the institutions around them, keep growing when the world changes faster than we can learn?

I design systems rather than courses: frameworks for identity, learning and leadership that people and organisations can use without me in the room. The Self-Learning Stack™ in this report is one of them.

Identity, method, systems

- → **Identity.** Multipotentials: a book and a Substack about building one life out of many interests
- → **Method.** The Self-Learning Stack™: how to stay irreplaceable when AI rewrites work
- → **Systems.** Models for universities, academies and organisations that grow brain capital

Where the ideas are tested

I run an IT consulting company for B2B SaaS and customer success, and I test these ideas in the field: in Women in Tech, in tech diplomacy across Central Asia and in the Cambridge Institute for Sustainability Leadership alumni community.

Before that I spent more than 15 years in MarTech, CRM and customer experience in global corporations. I write more than I speak.

AUTHOR
Multipotentials · The Self-Learning Stack™

IT CONSULTING
My company for B2B SaaS and customer success

WOMEN IN TECH
Leadership in a global network

TECH DIPLOMACY
TDGI Attaché

CAMBRIDGE CISL
Alumni community leader

15+ YEARS IN GLOBAL CORPORATIONS

PepsiCo **Alibaba Group** **Philip Morris International** **Otto Group**

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

ABOUT THIS REPORT

Building Brain Capital is report No. 2 in The Self-Learning Stack™ series. It translates the framework into a blueprint for learning institutions: universities, academies, business schools and corporate learning functions.

It is written for leadership teams and designed to be used without outside help: each chapter ends with something to do, and the toolkit gives your team the templates.

START HERE

Leadership: pages 5–6 and chapter 5. Run the workshop in Tool 4.

Contents

About the author 02

Foreword 04

Executive summary 05

At a glance 07

01 **Why institutions fall behind** 08

02 **The model** 11

03 **Community chapters** 17

04 **The venture lab** 24

05 **Making it work: maturity, measures, roadmap** 29

Toolkit 33

Sources and notes 38

The series 39

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

FOREWORD

Why a second report

The first report in this series, *Staying Irreplaceable*, was written for individuals. It describes The Self-Learning Stack™: three layers of learning, Tools, Meta-skills and Self-strategy, on a foundation of brain health, which together build a person's brain capital.

After every session about it, the same people came up to me: rectors, directors of academies, heads of learning and development. Their question was always the same. *If this is how people learn now, what should our institution look like?*

This report is my answer. It turns the stack into a blueprint for an institution: a university, a business school, an academy or a corporate learning function. It describes the units, the people who run them, the partners around them and the way to measure what they produce.

Two parts of the blueprint get special attention because they are the ones institutions find hardest and I know best: **community chapters**, which bring learning through people inside the institution, and the **venture lab**, which turns learning into products and companies.

The report is designed to be used without a consultant in the room. Each chapter ends with something you can do, and the toolkit at the end gives your team the templates to start.

Anna Ambrozevich

TASHKENT, 2026

WHO THIS IS FOR

- Rectors and vice-rectors
- Directors of academies and business schools
- Chief learning officers and L&D teams
- Heads of corporate universities
- Skills and education policy teams

HOW TO READ IT

Leadership: the executive summary and chapter 5. Programme teams: chapters 2–4. Everyone: the toolkit.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

From content provider *to brain capital builder*

When knowledge expires in a few years, an institution's value is no longer the content it holds. It is how well it grows people who can keep learning

SIX KEY FINDINGS

1 **Institutions teach three different layers in one format**

Tools, meta-skills and self-strategy change at different speeds, yet most universities and academies teach all of them through courses and exams.

2 **The answer is a layered institution**

A tech lab for tools, an academic core for meta-skills, a self-strategy studio for direction, all on a foundation of brain health.

3 **Learning through people needs a structure**

Community chapters led by practitioners keep an institution current. They work when the institution gives them space, resources and reach, and asks for knowledge in return.

4 **Learning should turn into value**

A venture lab gives strong projects a path from idea to pilot to product, with partners as first customers. In a company, the same unit is an intrapreneurship lab.

5 **What gets measured is brain capital, not credits**

The output of a learning institution is people who can keep learning. That can be measured with a small set of indicators across the layers.

6 **Start small and reversible**

One lab, two chapters and one studio module are enough to test the model in six months, before any large investment.

THE BLUEPRINT IN ONE LINE

Three floors, one foundation, three bridges to the world

Tech lab · academic core · self-strategy studio · brain health · tech partners · community chapters · venture lab

UNIVERSITIES AND COMPANIES

Every unit has a university and a corporate version. Chapter 2 maps them side by side.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY · THE FIRST 100 DAYS

Six decisions for the leadership team

None of them needs a new building or a new budget line to begin

1 **Name an owner for each layer**
Tools, meta-skills, self-strategy and brain health each need someone accountable, not one learning department for everything.

2 **Open one tech lab with one partner**
Practice only, current tools, monthly sprints. Start with a single AI company or platform.

3 **Launch two community chapters**
Pick two practitioners your people already learn from. Give them a room, a budget and a calendar.

4 **Add a self-strategy module**
A personal plan for every learner, revisited every term or every performance cycle.

5 **Set up a small venture lab**
One demo day, one pilot fund, one partner willing to be a first customer.

6 **Agree five brain capital indicators**
Measure before you scale, so the board sees evidence rather than enthusiasm.

RELATED REPORT

Staying Irreplaceable, report No. 1 in the series, explains the stack for individual learners. Many institutions give it to students and employees alongside this blueprint.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

AT A GLANCE

Why institutions have to change

Skills expire faster than programmes are renewed, and the economic value of the brain is now on the global agenda

EXHIBIT 1

Six figures for leadership teams

~5 years

is the half-life of learned skills, and falling

39%

of workers' core skills are expected to change by 2030

59 in 100

workers will need training by 2030

~60%

of jobs in advanced economies are exposed to AI, about 40% worldwide

$6.2T

cumulative GDP gains by 2050 from scaling brain health

267M

disability-adjusted life years that could be averted by 2050

Sources: Deloitte, 2017 Global Human Capital Trends (half-life). WEF, The Future of Jobs Report 2025 (39%; 59 in 100). IMF, SDN/2024/001 and IMF Blog, January 2024 (~60% / ~40%). WEF and McKinsey Health Institute, The Human Advantage, January 2026 ($6.2T; 267M).

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 01

Why institutions fall behind

A curriculum is built to be stable for years. The tools it teaches now change in months

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 01 · ONE FORMAT FOR EVERYTHING

The mismatch of speed

Most institutions teach every layer of learning the same way: a course, an assessment, a certificate

EXHIBIT 2

How institutions usually teach each layer, and what goes wrong

LAYER	UNIVERSITY	CORPORATE ACADEMY	WHAT GOES WRONG
Tools	Theory inside a fixed curriculum	A catalogue of e-learning courses	Out of date when delivered; little hands-on practice with current products
Meta-skills	Assumed, not trained	One-off soft-skills workshops	Learning stops at Input; nobody processes or produces
Self-strategy	A career day	An annual review form	People leave or stay without a direction
Brain health	Outside the curriculum	A wellbeing app	Burnout erodes the skills the institution is paying to build

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

None of this is a failure of teachers or L&D teams. It is a structural problem. A programme approved for five years cannot keep pace with tools that change every quarter, and a course catalogue cannot replace the practitioners who test those tools every week.

Meanwhile the newest knowledge has moved outside institutions: to vendor academies, to communities and to individual practitioners who share what they learn in public. Learners follow it there. The institution risks becoming the slowest source of knowledge in a learner's life.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 01 · THE SHIFT

From content provider to brain capital builder

EXHIBIT 3

Six shifts for a learning institution

~~Holds content~~	→	**Grows people who can keep learning**
~~One format for all learning~~	→	**A format for each layer**
~~Teachers as the only source~~	→	**Teachers, engineers, mentors and communities**
~~Closed campus or platform~~	→	**Open system with partners**
~~Credits and completions~~	→	**Brain capital indicators**
~~Learning ends at assessment~~	→	**Learning turns into projects and products**

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

The World Economic Forum and the McKinsey Health Institute describe the emerging **brain economy**, in which brain capital, brain health plus brain skills, becomes a strategic economic asset. If that is the asset, learning institutions are where it is produced.

That changes the question a rector or a chief learning officer has to answer. Not "which courses do we offer?" but "how much brain capital do we grow, and how do we know?"

For universities, this is a question of relevance: students and employers can see which institutions prepare people for continuous change. For companies, it is a question of capability: an organisation can only adopt AI as fast as its people can learn.

The rest of this report describes an institution designed around that question.

CHAPTER 02

The model

Three floors, one foundation and three bridges to the world.
One design for universities and corporate academies

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 02 · THE FOUNDATION OF THE MODEL

The Self-Learning Stack™ in one page

The blueprint is built on the framework from report No. 1. Each layer has its own speed, teachers and format

EXHIBIT 4

The stack, for institutional readers

LAYER 01 **Tools**	**Keep people current**	MONTHS
LAYER 02 **Meta-skills**	**Make people better learners**	YEARS
LAYER 03 **Self-strategy**	**Give learning a direction**	A CAREER
FOUNDATION **Brain health**		= Brain capital

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™, 2025–2026. Full description in report No. 1, Staying Irreplaceable.

Tools are the practical layer: AI platforms and software. They change fastest and are the easiest for AI to absorb. **Meta-skills** are how people learn and think: learning agility, sense-making, critical, systems and creative thinking.

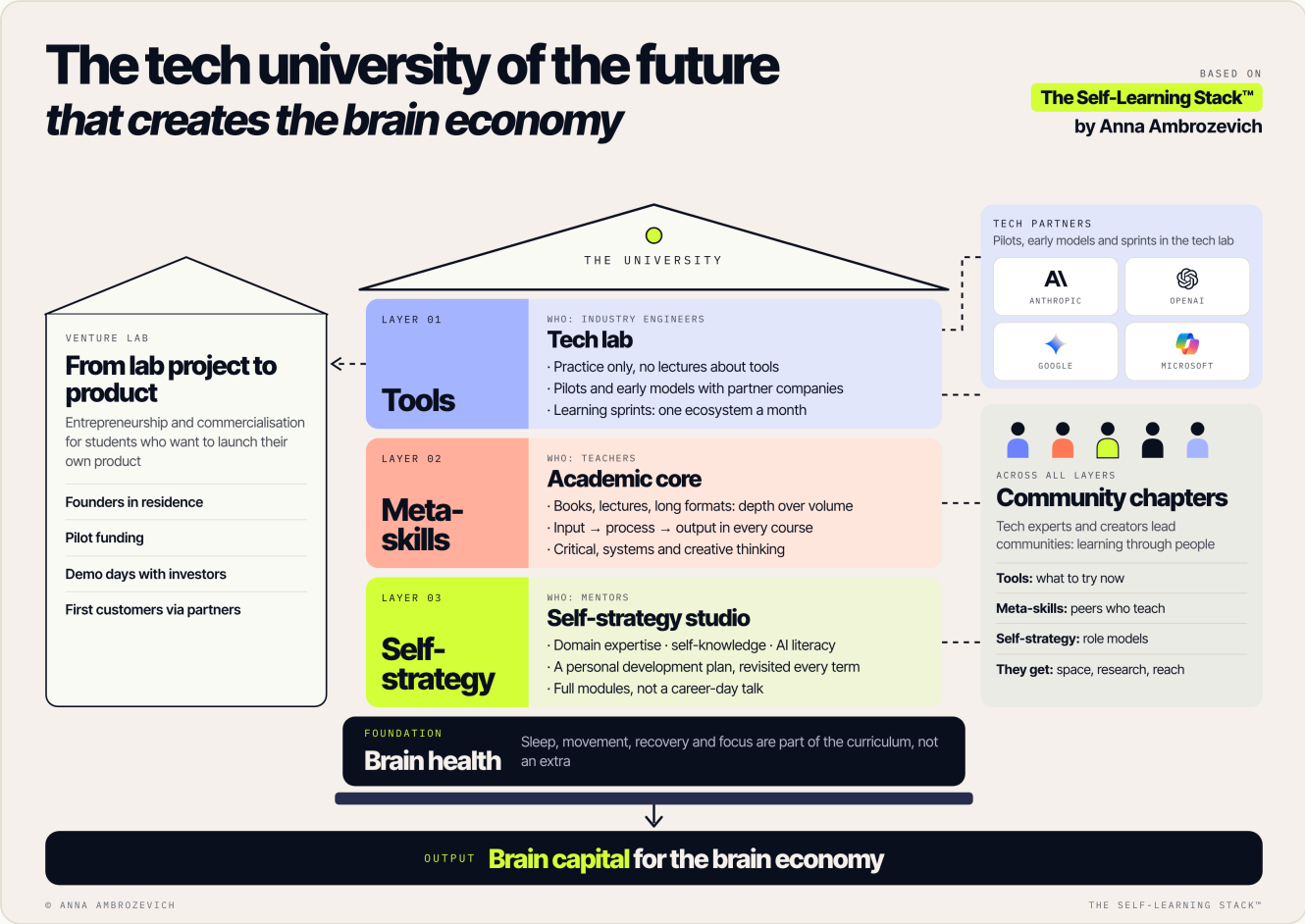
Self-strategy is direction: domain expertise, self-knowledge and AI literacy. **Brain health** is the foundation: sleep, movement, recovery and focus. An institution that builds all four produces brain capital.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 02 · THE BLUEPRINT

EXHIBIT 5

The tech university of the future, built on The Self-Learning Stack™



Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

The house has three floors, one for each layer, on a foundation of brain health. Its output is brain capital for the brain economy.

Three structures connect the house to the world: tech partners, community chapters and a venture lab for entrepreneurship and commercialisation.

CHAPTER 02 · THE FLOORS

Four units, four kinds of teacher

LAYER 01 · TOOLS

Tech lab

WHO TEACHES: INDUSTRY ENGINEERS

- Practice only, no lectures about tools
- Pilots and early models with partner companies
- Learning sprints: one ecosystem a month

LAYER 02 · META-SKILLS

Academic core

WHO TEACHES: TEACHERS

- Books, lectures and long formats: depth over volume
- Input → process → output in every course
- Critical, systems and creative thinking

LAYER 03 · SELF-STRATEGY

Self-strategy studio

WHO TEACHES: MENTORS

- Domain expertise · self-knowledge · AI literacy
- A personal development plan, revisited every term
- Full modules, not a career-day talk

FOUNDATION

Brain health

WHO TEACHES: HEALTH AND SPORT STAFF

- Sleep, movement, recovery and focus in the timetable
- For learners and staff alike
- Workload treated as a learning design decision

The key design choice is that each unit has a different kind of teacher. Engineers teach tools because they use them every day. Teachers teach meta-skills because depth is their craft. Mentors guide self-strategy because direction is personal.

Learners move through all four units at the same time. The floors are not tracks to choose between; they are layers every learner builds in parallel, at different speeds.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 02 · UNIVERSITIES AND COMPANIES

One blueprint, two kinds of institution

The units keep their purpose. Only their names and partners change

EXHIBIT 6

The blueprint in a university and in a corporate academy

UNIT	IN A UNIVERSITY OR ACADEMY	IN A CORPORATE ACADEMY OR L&D
Tech lab	Practice lab with partner companies	AI sandbox: approved tools, real data, monthly sprints
Academic core	Faculties, deep courses, research	Flagship programmes, reading circles, internal faculty
Self-strategy studio	Mentoring and personal plans every term	Career architecture, mentoring, development plans
Brain health	Sport, sleep and wellbeing in the timetable	Workload design, recovery, focus time
Tech partners	AI labs and platforms as lab partners	Vendor partnerships and early-access programmes
Community chapters	Practitioner-led communities on campus	Internal communities of practice and guilds
Venture lab	Entrepreneurship and commercialisation	Intrapreneurship lab and internal ventures

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

For a company, the blueprint answers a practical question: how do we help thousands of people adopt AI and keep adopting it, without buying a new course catalogue every year?

For a university, it answers a strategic one: how do we stay the place where people learn to keep learning, when content is available everywhere?

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 02 · THE TECH LAB AND PARTNERS

Teaching tools with the people who build them

The tech lab is the floor that changes fastest, so it cannot depend on a curriculum. It runs on **learning sprints**: one ecosystem a month, one week of immersion, and a real result at the end.

Industry engineers teach here, and partner companies provide access to their products, early models and real problems. Learners test tools before they reach the market and work on pilots with real data.

WHAT PARTNERS GIVE

- → Access to products and early models
- → Engineers as visiting teachers
- → Real pilot problems and data
- → First customers for venture lab projects

WHAT PARTNERS GET

- ← Early feedback from real users
- ← A pipeline of people trained on their tools
- ← Pilots and case studies
- ← Visibility in the community

EXHIBIT 7

A sprint calendar for the tech lab

MONTH 1

Ecosystem A

One week of immersion, one shipped result, one demo

MONTH 2

Ecosystem B

One week of immersion, one shipped result, one demo

MONTH 3

Ecosystem C

One week of immersion, one shipped result, one demo

MONTH 4

Ecosystem D

One week of immersion, one shipped result, one demo

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™. Rotate the main AI ecosystems; repeat the cycle three times a year.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 03

Community chapters

The new universities are people. Community chapters bring them inside the institution

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 03 · DEFINITION

What a community chapter is

A practitioner-led community that lives inside an institution, runs across all three layers and keeps the institution current

Most of what people learn about new tools today, they learn from other people: practitioners who test products every week, explainers who make sense of releases, peers one step ahead. Report No. 1 calls this **learning through people**.

A community chapter gives that learning a home. It is led by a tech expert, creator or practitioner whom learners already follow, and it meets regularly on campus or inside the company.

Chapters are not student clubs and not internal newsletters. They have a lead, a rhythm, a charter and an exchange with the institution: the institution gives space, resources and reach; the chapter gives current knowledge, networks and role models.

Researchers call related structures **communities of practice**: groups of people who share a concern and deepen their knowledge by interacting regularly. Chapters apply that idea to the speed of AI.

EXHIBIT 8

A chapter works across all three layers

TOOLS

What to try now

Demos of new tools, shared experiments, the 3-mention rule in practice.

META-SKILLS

Peers who teach

Members teach each other; every meeting produces Output, not only Input.

SELF-STRATEGY

Role models

Learners see real careers and paths, and find mentors.

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 03 · ROLES

Four roles in every chapter

EXHIBIT 9

Who does what

Chapter lead	A practitioner learners already learn from: a tech expert, creator or industry professional	Sets the theme and rhythm, curates speakers, represents the chapter
Co-hosts	Two or three active members, often senior students or employees	Run events, welcome newcomers, document what was learned
Members	Learners and staff who join by interest	Attend, experiment, share one thing they learned
Institution sponsor	A dean, director or L&D manager	Removes obstacles, connects the chapter to programmes and partners

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

Choosing a chapter lead

01 Learners already follow them or quote them

02 They show real work, not only opinions

03 They teach generously and credit others

04 They have time for a monthly rhythm

05 They are independent: not selling a course at every meeting

The lead is the single most important decision. A chapter with a strong lead and no budget will grow; a chapter with a budget and a weak lead will not.

Do not appoint leads from the org chart. Find them by asking learners whom they learn from, and invite those people.

> **Find leads by asking who people already learn from**

CHAPTER 03 · FORMATS

Six formats that keep a chapter alive

A chapter does not need all six. Two or three, held to a steady rhythm, are enough

EXHIBIT 10

The chapter format menu

Monthly meetup

90 MINUTES · OPEN

A demo, a short talk and an open discussion of what members are trying

Study circle

6–8 PEOPLE · 4–6 WEEKS

A small group works through one book, course or tool together and presents what they learned

Demo day

QUARTERLY

Members show projects built during sprints; partners and venture lab attend

Mentoring circle

MONTHLY

A role model meets a small group to discuss careers and self-strategy

Office hours

WEEKLY · 1 HOUR

The lead or co-hosts answer questions and review experiments

Open notes

CONTINUOUS

A shared space where every event leaves a short written summary

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

Rhythm beats intensity. A meetup every month for a year builds more than a big event every six months. Members plan their time around a predictable calendar.

Every event produces Output. A summary, a demo or a short post. That is what turns a meeting into learning, and it becomes the chapter's knowledge base.

Small groups do the deep work. Meetups bring people in; study circles and mentoring circles are where meta-skills and self-strategy actually grow.

Demo days connect the chapter to the rest of the house: the tech lab, partners and the venture lab all see what members are building.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 03 · THE EXCHANGE

What the institution gives, and what it gets

Chapters work when the exchange is explicit. Leads are not employees; they come for what the institution offers them

EXHIBIT 11

The chapter exchange

THE INSTITUTION GIVES

Space
A room, a time slot, a place on the calendar

Resources
A small budget, tools and licences, catering for events

Reach
Communication channels, partners, the institution's brand

Research
Data, academic support, a place to publish

→

←

THE CHAPTER GIVES

Current knowledge
What is actually being used, tested this month

Networks
Practitioners, companies and other communities

Role models
Real careers that learners can see and follow

Reputation
An institution known as the place where things happen

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

Write the exchange into a one-page **chapter charter**, signed by the lead and the institution sponsor. The toolkit at the end of this report has a template.

Review it once a year. If either side stops getting value, change the exchange or close the chapter. A closed chapter is not a failure; a zombie chapter is.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 03 · LIFECYCLE

The life of a chapter

EXHIBIT 12

Four stages of a chapter

MONTHS 0–3

Launch

Lead chosen, charter signed, first three meetups, first 20 members

MONTHS 3–12

Grow

Steady rhythm, co-hosts in place, first study circles and demo day

YEAR 2

Sustain

Knowledge base, links to programmes and partners, new co-hosts trained

EVERY YEAR

Renew or close

Review the charter: refresh the theme, hand over the lead, merge or close

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

Signs of a healthy chapter

+ Events happen on schedule, even small ones
+ New members arrive without being pushed
+ Members, not only the lead, present
+ Every event leaves a written summary
+ Projects from the chapter reach demo day or the venture lab

Common failure modes

– The lead is appointed, not chosen by learners
– The institution controls the agenda
– No budget, so the lead pays for everything
– Only Input: talks without experiments or output
– The lead burns out with no co-hosts

HOW MANY CHAPTERS?

Start with two, on themes learners already care about. Add one at a time, only when an existing chapter is healthy. A portfolio of five to eight strong chapters is enough for most institutions.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 03 · IN PRACTICE

Launch a chapter in 90 days

EXHIBIT 13

A 13-week launch plan

WEEKS 1–2	Ask learners whom they learn from; shortlist three potential leads
WEEKS 3–4	Meet the leads; agree theme, rhythm and the exchange; sign the charter
WEEKS 5–6	Book a room and a time slot for the year; announce the chapter
WEEK 7	First meetup: a demo and an open discussion
WEEKS 8–10	Recruit two or three co-hosts; start open notes
WEEKS 11–12	Second and third meetups; plan the first study circle
WEEK 13	Review with the sponsor: attendance, energy, first output

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

The plan is deliberately light. A chapter that needs a committee to start will not survive its first semester.

The sponsor's main job in these 90 days is to remove obstacles: rooms, approvals, budget. The lead's job is to make the first three meetings worth coming back to.

In a company, the same plan works for an internal community of practice. Replace "learners" with "employees", and invite one or two external practitioners to keep the chapter connected to the market.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 04

The venture lab

Entrepreneurship and commercialisation: from lab project to product

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 04 · PURPOSE

Why a learning institution needs a venture lab

Output is where meta-skills grow. A product is the strongest form of output there is

Report No. 1 describes how learning passes through Input, Process and Output, and why most people stop at Input. Institutions make the same mistake at scale: a strong project ends with a grade and disappears.

The venture lab gives those projects somewhere to go. It is a small unit for **entrepreneurship and commercialisation**: it helps learners who want to launch their own product move from a lab project to a pilot, a product and, sometimes, a company.

It also closes the loop with the rest of the house. Projects come from the tech lab and community chapters; partners provide first customers; the self-strategy studio helps founders decide whether this path is theirs.

In a company, the same unit is an **intrapreneurship lab**: employees turn internal ideas into pilots and new products, with business units as first customers.

EXHIBIT 14

Where venture lab projects come from

TECH LAB

Sprint results

Prototypes built in monthly sprints that solve a real problem.

COMMUNITY CHAPTERS

Demo day projects

Experiments that members want to take further.

PARTNERS

Pilot problems

Real challenges that partners are willing to pay to solve.

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 04 · THE PATH

From idea to venture in five stages

Each stage has a clear output and a gate. Most projects stop early, and that is part of the learning

EXHIBIT 15

The venture lab path

	STAGE	WHAT IT IS	WHAT THE LAB GIVES	GATE TO NEXT STAGE
01	**Idea**	A problem worth solving and a team that cares	Demo day pitch	Feedback from a chapter or partner
02	**Prototype**	A working version tested with real users	Lab support, tools, mentors	Five users who would use it again
03	**Pilot**	The product used by a partner in real conditions	Pilot funding, partner access	A partner willing to pay or extend
04	**Product**	A product with paying customers or internal adoption	Founders in residence, investor demo day	Revenue, adoption or investment
05	**Venture**	A company, a spin-off or a new internal business	Legal and IP support, investor network	Leaves the lab

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

The gates protect everyone's time. A project moves on when it has evidence, not when its team is enthusiastic. Evidence means users, partners and, eventually, money.

Many teams will stop at the prototype or pilot stage. They still leave with the strongest learning the institution can offer: they built something real and tested it in the world.

Build-measure-learn cycles, popularised by Eric Ries in *The Lean Startup*, fit this path well: small experiments, real feedback, fast decisions about whether to persevere or change direction.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 04 · PROGRAMMES

Four programmes that make the lab work

EXHIBIT 16

The venture lab toolkit

Founders in residence

Experienced founders spend time in the lab, mentor teams and run office hours

Pilot funding

Small grants that pay for a pilot with a partner, released at the prototype gate

Demo days with investors

Twice a year, the strongest teams pitch to investors and partners

First customers via partners

Tech partners and companies agree in advance to pilot lab products

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

Questions to settle before the first project

? Who owns the intellectual property of a student or employee project?

? What share, if any, does the institution take in a spin-off?

? How are partners' data and confidentiality protected in pilots?

? Who decides at each gate?

? What happens to a project when its team graduates or changes role?

These are policy and legal questions. Settle them with your legal team before launch; clear answers attract founders, unclear ones scare them away.

Common failure modes

- A lab with a sign on the door but no pilot funding
- Gates decided by enthusiasm, not evidence
- No partners committed as first customers
- IP rules that are unclear or unattractive to founders
- Measuring the number of start-ups instead of what people learned and built

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 04 · IN A COMPANY

The venture lab as an intrapreneurship lab

The path is the same. The founders are employees and the first customers are internal

EXHIBIT 17

University and corporate venture labs compared

	UNIVERSITY OR ACADEMY	COMPANY
Idea sources	Students, chapters, tech lab sprints	Employees, business units, customer problems
First customers	Tech partners and companies	Internal business units
Funding	Grants, partners, investors	Innovation budget, business unit sponsors
Typical output	Start-ups and spin-offs	New products, internal tools, new businesses
Main risk	Projects die after graduation	Projects die in the next budget cycle

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

In a company, the venture lab is where AI adoption becomes visible. Teams that learned a tool in the tech lab use it to rebuild a process or create a new service, and the business sees the result.

The biggest risk is time. Give intrapreneurs protected hours, a sponsor from the business and a clear decision date, or the project will lose to day-to-day work.

The metrics are also different. Count pilots adopted by business units, hours or costs saved, and new revenue, alongside what the teams learned.

WHAT THE VENTURE LAB MEASURES

- Projects entering each stage
- Share passing each gate
- Pilots with partners
- Products adopted or sold
- Founders and intrapreneurs trained
- What teams say they learned

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 05

Making it work

A maturity model, five indicators and a 36-month roadmap

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 05 · WHERE ARE YOU NOW?

The brain capital maturity model

Five levels across six dimensions. Most institutions sit at level 1 or 2 on most of them

EXHIBIT 18

From classic institution to brain capital institution

LEVEL	TOOLS	META-SKILLS	SELF-STRATEGY	BRAIN HEALTH	PARTNERS AND CHAPTERS	VENTURE LAB
1 · Classic	Tools taught as theory	Assumed	Career day	Outside scope	Ad hoc guest talks	None
2 · Aware	Some hands-on labs	Soft-skills workshops	Optional mentoring	Wellbeing app	One partner, a few events	Hackathons
3 · Piloting	A tech lab with one partner	Input → output in some courses	A self-strategy module	Recovery in the timetable	Two chapters with charters	Demo day and pilot fund
4 · Layered	Monthly sprints for all	Output assessed everywhere	A plan for every learner	Workload designed	Chapter portfolio, partner network	Full five-stage path
5 · Brain capital institution	Partners co-design the lab	Meta-skills measured	Plans drive programme choice	Brain health measured	Chapters shape the curriculum	Ventures fund the lab

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

Use the model as a diagnostic, not a ranking. Rate each dimension separately: an institution can be at level 4 on tools and level 1 on brain health.

The goal for the first 18 months is usually level 3 everywhere. Level 5 is a direction, not a deadline. The self-assessment in the toolkit turns this table into a workshop exercise.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 05 · MEASURING BRAIN CAPITAL

Five indicators instead of credits

Credits and completions measure what was covered. These indicators measure what people can do next

EXHIBIT 19

A brain capital dashboard

1	**Learning velocity**	Time for a learner to become productive with a new tool after a sprint	TOOLS
2	**Output ratio**	Share of learning hours that end in teaching, a project or a publication	META-SKILLS
3	**Plan coverage**	Share of learners with a written self-strategy reviewed in the last term or cycle	SELF-STRATEGY
4	**Brain health index**	Self-reported sleep, recovery and focus, tracked anonymously over time	BRAIN HEALTH
5	**Ecosystem reach**	Active chapters, partners and venture lab projects passing a gate	BRIDGES

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026. Indicators are proposed; adapt definitions to your data.

Start by measuring a baseline before any change, even roughly. Without it, the board will judge the model on anecdotes.

Keep the dashboard small. Five indicators reviewed every term are more useful than fifty reviewed never.

Brain health data is personal. Collect it anonymously and in aggregate, explain why it is collected, and never use it to evaluate individuals.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

CHAPTER 05 · ROADMAP

Three phases over 36 months

The first phase is designed to be cheap and reversible, and to produce the evidence a board needs

EXHIBIT 20

A roadmap to a layered institution

PHASE 1 · 0–6 MONTHS

Pilot

- One tech lab with one partner
- Two community chapters with charters
- A self-strategy module in one programme
- Baseline for the five indicators

PHASE 2 · 6–18 MONTHS

Scale

- Learning sprints across technical programmes
- Input → output assessment in the academic core
- Brain health in the timetable
- Demo day and a first pilot fund

PHASE 3 · 18–36 MONTHS

Institutionalise

- Venture lab with founders in residence
- A chapter portfolio and partner network
- A self-strategy plan for every learner
- Brain capital dashboard reported to the board

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026. Timelines are indicative.

Who owns what

- **Leadership sponsor:** the case, the budget, the board
- **Layer owners:** one person for each floor and the foundation
- **Chapter sponsor:** charters and the exchange
- **Venture lab lead:** the path, gates and partners
- **Data owner:** the five indicators

The model works for a technical university, a business school, a corporate academy or a national skills programme. The floors stay the same; the partners and the scale change.

Resist the temptation to launch everything at once. One healthy chapter and one working lab are more persuasive than a strategy document.

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

TOOLKIT

Templates for your team

Four tools to run the first workshop and launch the first units, without outside help

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

TOOL 1

Institutional self-assessment

Rate each dimension from 1 to 5 using the maturity model. Do it separately, then compare in the leadership team

Tools 1 2 3 4 5

Meta-skills 1 2 3 4 5

Self-strategy 1 2 3 4 5

Brain health 1 2 3 4 5

Partners and chapters 1 2 3 4 5

Venture lab 1 2 3 4 5

OUR STRONGEST DIMENSION

TARGET LEVEL IN 18 MONTHS

OUR WEAKEST DIMENSION

FIRST UNIT WE WILL LAUNCH

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

TOOL 2

Community chapter charter

One page, signed by the lead and the sponsor, reviewed once a year

CHAPTER NAME AND THEME

LEAD

CO-HOSTS

INSTITUTION SPONSOR

RHYTHM AND FORMATS

Monthly meetup, study circles...

THE INSTITUTION GIVES

Space, resources, reach, research

THE CHAPTER GIVES

Knowledge, networks, role models

HOW WE WILL KNOW IT WORKS

Attendance, output, projects at demo day

REVIEW DATE

SIGNED · CHAPTER LEAD

SIGNED · INSTITUTION SPONSOR

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

TOOL 3

Venture lab gate review

Use at every gate. A project moves on with evidence, not enthusiasm

PROJECT

CURRENT STAGE → NEXT STAGE

Evidence

Users, partners, pilots, revenue: what has actually happened?

What the team learned

The strongest lesson from this stage

What the next stage needs

Funding, access, mentors, partners

Risks and open questions

IP, data, time, team

DECISION ☐ Move on ☐ Iterate and return ☐ Stop and capture lessons

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

TOOL 4

A three-hour leadership workshop

Run it yourselves. You need this report, Tool 1 printed for everyone, and one decision-maker in the room

EXHIBIT 21

Workshop agenda

0:00	**Why now**	Read the executive summary together; share one reaction each
0:20	**Where are we**	Individual self-assessment (Tool 1), then compare scores
1:00	**Break**	
1:10	**Choose the first units**	Pick one tech lab partner, two chapter themes and one studio module
1:50	**Owners and dates**	Name layer owners, chapter sponsor and a 90-day review date
2:30	**Indicators**	Agree the five indicators and who measures the baseline
3:00	**Close**	One sentence each: what I will do this week

Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™ applied to institutional design, 2026.

AFTER THE WORKSHOP

01 Send the decisions to all participants within 48 hours

02 Book the first chapter meetups and the first sprint week

03 Meet again in 90 days with the baseline indicators

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

SOURCES AND NOTES

Sources

01 World Economic Forum (2025). The Future of Jobs Report 2025. Geneva: World Economic Forum.

02 World Economic Forum and McKinsey Health Institute (2026). The Human Advantage: Stronger Brains in the Age of AI. Insight report, January 2026.

03 Cazzaniga, M. et al. (2024). Gen-AI: Artificial Intelligence and the Future of Work. IMF Staff Discussion Note SDN/2024/001. Figures as summarised in K. Georgieva, IMF Blog, 14 January 2024.

04 Deloitte (2017). Careers and learning: Real time, all the time. In: Rewriting the rules for the digital age: 2017 Deloitte Global Human Capital Trends. Deloitte University Press.

05 Wenger, E. (1998). Communities of Practice: Learning, Meaning, and Identity. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

06 Wenger, E., McDermott, R. and Snyder, W. M. (2002). Cultivating Communities of Practice. Boston: Harvard Business School Press.

07 Ries, E. (2011). The Lean Startup. New York: Crown Business.

08 Ambrozevich, A. (2026). Staying Irreplaceable: How people and institutions keep growing when the world changes faster than we can learn. Insight report No. 1, The Self-Learning Stack™ series.

Figures are quoted as published by their sources. The blueprint, the maturity model, the indicators and all exhibits marked "The Self-Learning Stack™" are the author's own. Questions of intellectual property and spin-off policy in chapter 4 are listed for discussion and are not legal advice.

USING THIS REPORT

© 2026 Anna Ambrozevich. A purchased copy may be shared and used inside the purchasing institution, including the toolkit templates. Exhibits may be quoted with attribution: "Source: Anna Ambrozevich, The Self-Learning Stack™".

THE SELF-LEARNING STACK™ SERIES

Two reports, one system

One for every learner. One for the institutions that grow them

REPORT NO. 1

Staying Irreplaceable

For professionals, students and employees. The Self-Learning Stack™ explained layer by layer, with a 90-day plan and worksheets.

REPORT NO. 2 · THIS REPORT

Building Brain Capital

For rectors, academy leaders and L&D teams. The blueprint, community chapters, the venture lab, a maturity model and a toolkit.

COPIES FOR YOUR PEOPLE

Many institutions give report No. 1 to every student or employee taking part in the first phase, so the whole institution shares one language for learning.

LINKEDIN

Anna Ambrozevich

Follow for new reports

SUBSTACK

@multipotentials

Essays on learning and identity

© 2026 ANNA AMBROZEVICH

BUILDING BRAIN CAPITAL

The output of a learning institution *is people who can keep learning*

